In contrast, confidence is based on evidence and firsthand observation. Confidence does not involve the same degree of risk that trust does because we're not relying as much on another party.

For example, we fly with confidence that the plane will not crash because we've flown before and can find evidence of flight safety. We have confidence that the airline and government have properly vetted the pilots, flight crew, mechanics, and air traffic controllers. We don't have to know how to fly or fix a plane to know these things.

At the same time, we are vulnerable to that vetting process and the behavior of the people in those critical positions. Pilots make errors and mechanics miss problems. This shows that trust and confidence are not a binary proposition. Rather, there's a spectrum. Increasing confidence in something allows us to reduce our vulnerability and thus our need to trust.

2.6.2 Trust and confidence in digital relationships

Because of the proximity problem, both operators and users of digital identity systems are vulnerable to being deceived by the other. Phishing, at its root, is caused by people trusting a link, text, or email they shouldn't have because of false confidence inspired by poorly designed systems. Because the system doesn't provide true confidence signals, we teach people to protect themselves by being less trusting.

There are many risks in a digital identity system:

- Is this account compromised?
- Have the attributes the IdP returned been verified?
- Am I connected to the right website or using the right app?
- Does this role have the correct level of access?
- Can this account be leveraged to gain access to another?

These and many other questions underlie the level of confidence an identity system inspires, or the trust it requires.